IAF since 2019, India currently operates only 22 units. The delivery of six additional Apaches for the army, as part of a $600 million (Rs 5,200 crore) deal signed with the US in 2020, is delayed due to supply chain disruptions.

Some analysts argue that the Apache, optimised for lower-altitude combat in regions like the Middle East, may not be as effective in the Himalayas. In contrast, the Prachand was specifically built for high-altitude combat, a capability it demonstrated even before its official induction when it was deployed in Leh during the 2020 Galwan clash with China.

The Prachand's narrow fuselage, stealth-enhanced design, and reduced radar and infrared signature improve survivability in contested airspace. HAL has also incorporated a crashworthy bottom structure and reinforced crew seats to enhance pilot safety during high-impact landings while a hingeless main rotor and bearing-less tail rotor improves durability. The helicopter's advanced Electro-Optical Pod and Helmet Mounted Display System give pilots real-time targeting and enhanced situational awareness.

According to HAL's chairman and managing director D.K. Sunil, the project has become a flagship for India's indigenous engineering, encouraging private-sector participation in the defence sector. "It's the first fully indigenous attack helicopter developed in India and the only one worldwide operable at 5,000 metres," he told INDIA TODAY, while emphasising that the agency delivered the initial batch of 15 helicopters ahead of schedule. Whether operating in the unforgiving heights of Ladakh or supporting counter-insurgency missions, the Prachand is ready to live up to its name—fierce, formidable, and built for battle. ■

CPI(M)

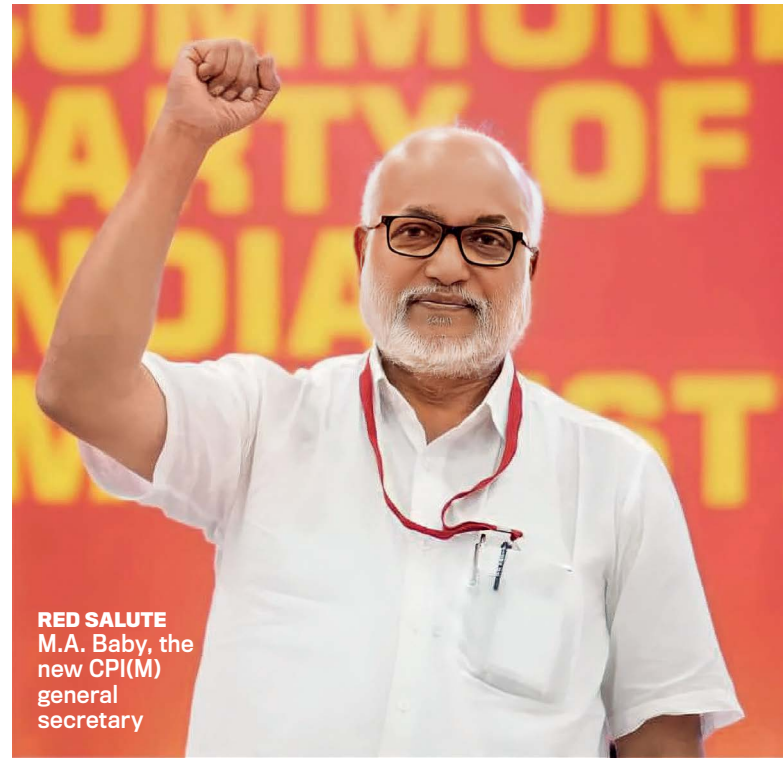
HARD ROAD AHEAD FOR BABY

By Jeemon Jacob

Mariam Alexander Baby, a soft-spoken and erudite veteran who once helmed Kerala's storied education policy as minister, has taken over as the new CPI(M) general secretary. The top post within the party had been lying vacant since Sitaram Yechury passed away last September, and the 71-year-old Baby inherits the suite of complex challenges that come with the territory. It's a shrinking one: the country's biggest Marxist party is now reduced to holding fort along a sliver at its southern tip, having lost old bastions like West Bengal and Tripura.

The CPI(M)'s 24th all-India party congress at Madurai (April 2-6) also elected an 18-member politburo and 85-member central committee that saw the debut of 30 new leaders. It marked a generational shift in the party leadership, with veterans like the Karats (Prakash and wife Brinda), Subhashini Ali, Manik Sarkar, Suryakanta Mishra and G. Ramakrishna bowing out from the politburo after an age cap (75 years) was adopted. The 79-year-old Kerala chief minister, Pinarayi Vijayan, though, retained his place.

The new general secretary reiterated that he would also be leading the Left Front campaign in Kerala's 2026 assembly election. Among the new politburo members are Dr Vijoo Krishnan, 51, who conceived of the impactful 2018 farmers' march in Maharashtra; R. Arunkumar, 51, son of CITU (Centre of Indian Trade Unions) president K. Hemalatha; Amra Ram, who broke a long jinx for the party as the lone Communist



RED SALUTE M.A. Baby, the new CPI(M) general secretary